

# How Often Should I...?

The cadences nobody tells you, in one place.

DAILY

Every day

≈10 minutes

| TASK                                                                                              | GOOD ENOUGH      | BETTER             |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|--------------------|
| Dishes washed or in the dishwasher                                                                | Before bed       | After each meal    |
| Kitchen counters wiped                                                                            | Before bed       | As you cook        |
| Stovetop wiped                                                                                    | While still warm | After each use     |
| Things put back where they live                                                                   | Once, before bed | As you go          |
| Make the bed                                                                                      | Most days        | Daily              |
| Dryer lint trap  | Every load       | Every load         |
| Food put away, nothing left out                                                                   | Before bed       | Right after eating |

WEEKLY

Every week

45–90 minutes

| TASK                                | GOOD ENOUGH       | BETTER                           |
|-------------------------------------|-------------------|----------------------------------|
| Bathroom — toilet, sink, mirror     | Weekly            | Twice weekly                     |
| Shower or tub                       | Every 1–2 weeks   | Weekly                           |
| Vacuum main areas                   | Weekly            | Twice weekly, or daily with pets |
| Mop hard floors                     | Every 2 weeks     | Weekly                           |
| Dust surfaces                       | Every 2 weeks     | Weekly                           |
| Change sheets                       | Every 2 weeks     | Weekly                           |
| Clear out the fridge                | Before you shop   | —                                |
| Laundry                             | Weekly, set day   | —                                |
| Wipe down the microwave             | Weekly            | When it splatters                |
| Check bank accounts                 | Weekly, 5 min     | —                                |
| Plan the week, look at the calendar | Weekly, 20–30 min | —                                |

## BY USE, NOT BY CALENDAR

| ITEM                  | WASH OR REPLACE AFTER                                                                    |
|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Bath towels           | 3–4 uses                                                                                 |
| Hand towels           | 2–3 days                                                                                 |
| Kitchen dish towels   | 2–3 days                                                                                 |
| Kitchen sponge        | Replace every 1–2 weeks                                                                  |
| Pillowcases           | With sheets — more often with acne, eczema, allergies, night sweats, or a pet in the bed |
| Bras                  | 2–3 wears                                                                                |
| Jeans                 | 4–5 wears — genuinely, not a myth                                                        |
| Bath mat              | Every 1–2 weeks                                                                          |
| Reusable water bottle | Daily — the one people skip                                                              |

MONTHLY

Every month

| TASK                                                                                                            | GOOD ENOUGH | BETTER  |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|---------|
| Test smoke and CO detectors  | Monthly     | Monthly |

| TASK                               | GOOD ENOUGH      | BETTER            |
|------------------------------------|------------------|-------------------|
| Dishwasher filter — pull and rinse | Monthly          | Every 2 weeks     |
| Washing machine — hot empty cycle  | Monthly          | Monthly           |
| Garbage disposal                   | Monthly          | Every 2 weeks     |
| Drains — flush with hot water      | Monthly          | —                 |
| Oven interior                      | Every 3 months   | Monthly           |
| Fridge — full wipe-out             | Monthly          | —                 |
| Air filter — check it              | Monthly          | —                 |
| Vacuum under and behind furniture  | Monthly          | —                 |
| Review spending                    | Monthly          | —                 |
| Shower head — descale              | Every 3 months   | Monthly           |
| Wash pillows                       | Every 3–6 months | Quarterly         |
| Replace toothbrush                 | Every 3 months   | After illness too |

SEASONAL

Every 3–6 months

| TASK                                                       | WHEN                                                                    |
|------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Air filter — change it                                     | Every 1–3 months. Sooner with pets. The size is printed on the old one. |
| Baseboards and door frames                                 | Quarterly                                                               |
| Windows, inside                                            | Quarterly                                                               |
| Light fixtures and ceiling fans                            | Quarterly                                                               |
| Refrigerator coils — vacuum                                | Twice a year                                                            |
| Flip or rotate the mattress                                | Every 6 months — check the manufacturer first                           |
| Wash comforter or duvet                                    | Every 3–6 months                                                        |
| Deep clean one room at a time                              | Rotate quarterly — never all at once                                    |
| Review subscriptions                                       | Quarterly. Cancel what you forgot about.                                |
| Check that your backups actually restore <a href="#">△</a> | Quarterly — the step everyone skips                                     |
| Dentist                                                    | Every 6 months, or as your dentist says                                 |

ANNUAL

Once a year

| TASK                                              | NOTES                                                            |
|---------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Dryer vent duct — clean <a href="#">△</a>         | <b>Fire risk.</b> Not the lint trap — the duct behind the dryer. |
| Smoke and CO detector batteries <a href="#">△</a> | Pick a memorable date and keep it                                |
| Water heater — flush                              | Renting? This is your landlord's job — report it.                |
| Gutters                                           | Twice a year, if they're yours                                   |
| Caulk and grout — inspect                         | Re-seal before water gets behind it                              |
| Check for leaks under every sink                  | Five minutes; catches expensive problems                         |

| TASK                                      | NOTES                                 |
|-------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Insurance review                          | Renter's, auto, health — at renewal   |
| Credit report check                       | Free from the official federal source |
| Gather tax documents                      | January                               |
| Physical / annual checkup                 | Or as your provider advises           |
| Eye exam                                  | Every 1–2 years                       |
| Wardrobe clear-out                        | Annually                              |
| Review this list against your actual life | Annually                              |

VEHICLE

Check your manual first

Intervals vary a lot by vehicle, oil type, and how you drive. Treat these as "go look it up," not as the answer.

| TASK                        | TYPICAL GUIDANCE                                                                |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Oil change                  | <b>Follow your owner's manual.</b> The old 3,000-mile rule is usually obsolete. |
| Tire pressure               | Monthly, and before long trips. Check when tires are cold.                      |
| Tire rotation               | Per manual — commonly every other oil change                                    |
| Registration and inspection | Per your state. <b>Put the expiration on a calendar.</b>                        |
| Wiper blades                | Every 6–12 months, or when they streak                                          |
| Air filter, brakes, fluids  | Per manual; checked at each service                                             |

NOW

When "as needed" means today

| SITUATION                                                                                                                 | DO IT                                                                  |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A spill                                                                                                                   | Immediately. Wet is 10 seconds; dried is 3 minutes.                    |
| A stain on clothing                                                                                                       | Immediately. Set stains are usually permanent.                         |
| A slow drip or running toilet                                                                                             | This week. Cheap fix, expensive flood.                                 |
| <b>A stain appearing on a ceiling</b>  | <b>Today.</b> Report it in writing if you rent.                        |
| Smoke detector chirping                                                                                                   | Today. The battery is dying.                                           |
| Anything your landlord is responsible for                                                                                 | Report in writing, immediately. The paper trail protects your deposit. |